When the IPL was originally launched by the BCCI in late 2007, there was, understandably, a lot of apprehension surrounding the tournament. Indian cricket had to come to terms with the club culture, and the concept of player auctions was alien to the average Indian cricket fan. No one was quite sure what standard the cricket would be or whether fans would come out to support the tournament in the oppressive heat of April and May.

A confession is in order here. While I never had any doubt that the IPL would be popular, I did not expect the tournament to take off quite so quickly. Secondly, I did not expect the standard of cricket to be so high. The matches in the IPL are played with as much intensity as international cricket and the level is very close to the highest international standard. Players turning up for the franchises always give their best and the fans appreciate this and, of course, they also enjoy seeing the world's best players in action alongside the best of Indian domestic talent.

Differences from international cricket

There are some fundamental differences between the IPL and international cricket. One is the close involvement of the team owners. Their presence adds to the character of the tournament. For example, some have their own peculiar superstitions, which they impose on the team. In one team the owner's priest decides when the players should leave their hotel rooms on match days, and the players go along with this. Whatever state the players are in, they have to leave the room.

Another team owner believes in 'vastu' (which is a little like feng shui) and their dressing room is always organized in a particular manner, with mirrors set at specific angles. Once in a match against us this team even went ahead and changed our dressing room, putting in mirrors just as they did at their home venue. In turn, we changed this arrangement late at night and all the mirrors were covered with towels to unsettle the opposition.

On another occasion we were told by one team management not to use a washroom in our dressing room and a sign was placed outside it declaring '*BATHROOM OUT OF ORDER*'. One of the players couldn't resist going in, just to have a look, only to discover that it was working